

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 246

Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1963-1973

Coverage Date: 1963-1973

Place Coverage: Dobe Area, Botswana And Namibia

Section Title(S): Hunting Success And Status Differences

To these insults the hunter must not act offended; he should respond in kind, with self-demeaning words:

626
Social Control

"You're right, this one is not worth the effort; let's just cook the liver for strength and leave the rest for the hyenas. It is not too late to hunt today and even a duiker or a steenbok would be better than this mess."

The party, of course, has no intention of abandoning the kill. The heavy joking and derision are directed toward one goal: the leveling of potentially arrogant behavior in a successful hunter. The !Kung recognize the tendency toward arrogance (*≠twi*) in young men and take definite steps to combat it. As *≠*Tomazho, the famous healer from /Xai/xai, put it:

626
Social Control

867
Transmission Of
Cultural Norms

When a young man kills much meat, he comes to think of himself as a chief or a big man, and he thinks of the rest of us as his servants or inferiors. We can't accept this. We refuse one who boasts, for someday his pride will make him kill somebody. So we always speak of his meat as worthless. In this way we cool his heart and make him gentle.

Even though some men are much better hunters than others, their behavior is molded by the group to minimize the tendency toward self-aggrandizement and to channel their energies into socially beneficial activities. As a result, the existence of differences in hunting prowess does not lead to a system of Big Men in which a few talented individuals tower over others in terms of prestige.

626
Social Control

867
Transmission Of
Cultural Norms

Two further aspects of egalitarianism among !Kung hunters should be mentioned: the use of hunting magic to improve poor hunting results in the widespread practice of sharing arrows and ownership for kills. If a hunter is down on his luck, he may request another man to touch up his first buck tattoos. The older man spends up to an hour opening the old cuts and rubbing fresh medicine into the tattoos. The knuckle cracking and other rituals are also performed. If a hunter has made a small kill and wants to make a big one, the blood from the small kill is rubbed on his bow to strengthen it. If a man is very dissatisfied with his hunting results, he may discard his present bow and quiver and build new ones  247 from scratch. Other forms of hunting magic revolve around the correct butchering and distribution of meat from previous kills. The !Kung believe that the women must never eat the men's part of the animals or hunting success will drop to zero. In one case of hunting failure the explanation offered was that an inexperienced young man had cooked meat for the women in a pot that had not been thoroughly cleaned with water, sand, and ash after the men's portions had been cooked in it. In days before the advent of the iron kettle, this kind of contamination must have been rarer because most of the meat was roasted in the fire. Only since the cooking pot has come into use has the danger of mixing tabooed parts arisen (Marks 1976:125).

224
[Hunting And Trapping](#)

777
[Luck And Chance](#)

784
[Avoidance And Taboo](#)

788
[Ritual](#)

789
[Magic](#)

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)